

UNEQUAL PARTNERS

Women are more open to trying out their partner's fantasies compared to their male counterparts. This is how it plays out in the conjugal bedroom:



Rest don't know/can't say.
All figures in per cent.

In the 51-60 age group, 31 per cent are yet to enact their partner's fantasies. Men fare the worst at 42 per cent compared to women (22 per cent).

stars, celebrities, and movie-item girls versus 76 per cent wives. In their mental forays, 35 per cent husbands found women from other castes sexually attractive, 48 per cent said they fantasised about rural women, and 14 per cent would even have sex with underage girls. In contrast, unmarried and married women were different. Unmarried women don't use sex toys (93 per cent) nor do married women (95 per cent). They don't even think about using them (87 per cent in both categories). Married women mostly do not fantasise about role play, 62 per cent don't watch porn films but the ones that do (36 per cent) watch that star a man and woman.

Using glimpses of the above, three points can be made: One, such gender disparities in sexual preferences suggest how important physical pleasure and emotional satisfaction is for women in relationships as a necessary and preliminary step even before they can imagine experimentation. Two, survey respondents could have imagined making out in mile-high clubs and on beaches, but curiously, they didn't. Seventy-seven per cent husbands and 78 per cent wives fantasised about having sex in their own bedrooms, which is perhaps due to the income group they were in. And yet, even though their fantasies were spatially constrained, their access to sexually available partners clearly wasn't. Three, a substantial portion of husbands reported sexual liaisons outside marriage and additionally with 15 per cent married men admitting to having a girlfriend compared to wives (only 4 per cent had boyfriends).

For this group at least, the highest sexual risk for married women was to be married to a man with female friend(s) or with access to female neighbours; for the higher income groups, my research finds, the marital sexual risk for an urban Indian woman is similar to the urban Chinese wife: it is to be married to a man in a high income group who travels. This suggests that with globalisation, our sexual risks don't just become higher, they also become different. It also raises a public health question for us. Should sexual safety options be directed not just at truck stops but also in



Model HIDA. Location courtesy THE PARK, NEW DELHI

neighbourhoods, hotels and airports?

Everyone dreams a little of making out with a woman in a red scarf but when our imaginations carry marriage, it is torn apart, separating partners who inhabit different worlds. With growing Internet use, and travel alongside complicit cultural beliefs—"it is hardwired in men", "it is a man's *fitrat*", "men can separate sex from emotion"—forays into infidelity are more likely for one gender. But it deprives marriage of valuable opportunities and makes it no happier nor sex more fulfilling. With deep sexual unhappiness in urban middle-class India, yes, it is the right time to imagine, to reimagine, a marriage with sexy spaces together, not alone. Until that happens, like Avanti, many women will be figuring it out on their own: "Unless a woman is aroused, she is not going to enjoy it."

The writer is a clinical psychologist and author of Love Will Follow: Why the Indian Marriage is Burning.